

At The Tiller

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Synchronicity happens.

Recently, we in Distelfink Sippschaft were talking about ways to work with the concepts of change, transformation, and even the trickster beings, etc., and discussing the possibility of setting up observances in April to explore those ideas. April is a good time since the weather is improving but still unpredictable.

At about the same time, someone in a Deutsch online forum asked about the “moving day,” when Deutsch tenant farmers would move the whole family from one farm to another. Typically, the date of this was indeed April 1 (although if the farmer had any cattle, in certain years cattle-driving superstitions would require them to shift the date, and I am sure many Christian farmers would not move on a Sunday).

This moving day is known as *der Ziegdaag* (“dah TSEEK-dawg”), and the actual move is known, at least in the community I grew up in, as *es Geflitze* (“ehs k’FLEE-tseh”) or, in English, the Flitting. This was a big deal in the not-too-distant past, as many families were doing this move simultaneously. We have firsthand reports of what it was like. There could be scores or even hundreds of families moving along the same roads. Farms changed hands, but the practice was not limited to farmers. Other industries were involved in the move. Mechanics, hotelkeepers, and other businesses whose leases were not renewed would be flitting at the same time.

This practice was not limited to the Deitscherei. Similar movements took place in Boston and New York, but at different times of the year. [Editor’s note: Medieval Iceland also had *farðagar*, “moving days”; these fell near the end of May.] For the Deitsch, April 1 was the standard day, and that is very likely due to the timing of planting. While April has unstable weather, it is a bit more less likely than March to get snow. More important, farmers needed to complete their move with enough time to prepare for planting. Some significant crops go into the ground in April, so April 1 is in the narrow window between the harshness of March and the time when these crops must go into the ground.

It was customary for one wagon, the *Offewagge*, to carry the oven and to be the first to arrive at the new home. That way, the oven could be assembled so that the first meal could be prepared. Neighbors would pitch in to help, so it was a community event, even though ending friendships caused sorrow and multiple moves taking place at once caused chaos.

So, how does this day fit into Urglaawe practice?

We have an established Deutsch event focused on change, taking place at a time when we are looking for ways to observe the need or the desire for change and out-of-the-box thinking. So we are taking this holiday and reframing it from a focus on the change of physical location to change around and within ourselves.

Within our context, *der Ziegdaag* is about change or transformation in all aspects: the need for change, the fear of change, the agents of change, the trickster figures, and the sagacious figures who solve problems, escape from traps, or change the world.

This observance pairs nicely with April Fool’s Day and the unpredictable weather at this particular time of year.

In terms of the *Lewesraad*, or the wheel of the year, *der Ziegdaag* represents the time of transition from childhood into adolescence, when change is difficult and awkward, yet is a part of life that we must go through.

I have heard it said that Loki is the only trickster-figure in Germanic lore, but local legends from different regions of Germany and / or the Deitscherei offer several such entities whom we acknowledge on *Ziegdaag*.

Characters

Unlike the Norse lore about Loki, Urglaawe lore does not have one particularly prominent agent of change. Instead, our folklore is studded with innumerable



Moving Day

Image retrieved from <http://explorepahistory.com/display-image.php?imgId=1-2-108> (Courtesy of the Schwenkfelder Library and Heritage Center, Pennsburg, PA)

characters, some of whom may be based on real people, others who have their origins in Heathen lore, and yet others who are entities whose lore we are still picking apart. This year, we will focus mostly on the Mountain Giant known as Riewezaahl, but we will look at a few others as well.

Schadde

Schadde (sometimes appears as Schaade) is a trickster figure in a fragmentary Deitsch story in which he manipulates Schlumm, a deity or giant associated with sleep, into blowing darts that put starcrossed lovers Sunna and /or Muun to sleep, thus allowing for Schadde to place them in the sky so they will never be able to consummate their love. He does this out of jealousy, yet this action creates the tides that allow life on Earth to thrive. Sunna and Muun meet at eclipses, and they are able to use light and reflection to have children on the Earth in the form of dandelions. There appears to be a reckoning that results in Schadde having to restrict his own movement, but this part is unclear. This story is, unfortunately, missing some other pieces, too, and we have not finished putting what we do have in order. However, Schadde appears in at least two other fragments of tales, both of which appear to involve cunning and /or setting things straight for the betterment of all involved.

Till Eileschpiggel

Perhaps based on tales about an actual person, the stories of Till are widely known in the German, Dutch, and Flemish cultures. Till is a true trickster in many ways. He thinks outside the box, periodically engages in buffoonery, and has a knack for overturning conventional wisdom. His name reflects the latter; "Eileschpiggel" translates to "owl mirror," with the owl representing wisdom, and the mirror symbolizing the reflection or the opposite of that wisdom. In some sense, Till is an anti-hero, but, at this time of year, it is worth considering the wit and out-of-the-box thinking that are the inspirations for this character.

Riewezaahl – Der Bariyeharr - Rips

NOTE: Do not address him directly as Riewezaahl, Riebzaahl, Rübezahl, or anything similar. The term of respect is *Der Bariyeharr* or the Mountain Lord, but he calls himself Rips when in human form.

This Giant, whose nickname means "turnips count," is known in the lore of both Germanic and Slavic cultures. During an interview with a Hexerei practitioner, the topic of the Frost Giants' Wonnetzeit attack came up, and the elderly woman asked me if I knew much of Riewezaahl ("turnips count"). I had not heard of this being prior to this conversation, and she told me she remembered her mother talking about Riewezaahl. She said that her mother described Riewezaahl as an irritable Mountain Giant who has a great ability to bring about unstable weather and would occasionally simply cause trouble because "that is what Giants do." Since that time, I have come across a few other references to him, including tales in which he causes squalls and sudden windstorms, earthquakes, and more.

Rübezahl appears in many Silesian legends, and historically there is a strong Silesian presence among the Deitsch in the particular area in which I was doing interviews. Although some of the references I am coming across treat him like a woodsprite, gnome, or god, there is more evidence to indicate that he is not a pleasant spirit and has more attributes that would place him among the Giants, specifically a Mountain Giant.

The lore emanates mostly from the Germans and Slavs of Silesia and Bohemia. Grimm (Volume II, p. 480) refers to him as a wood-sprite and has some notes that that may link him to Knecht Ruprecht, but there is not much description there.

Silesia has a very troubled history and was a major point of contention between competing states and cultures for centuries, ultimately resulting in the expulsion of its German population after WWII. We need to keep this observance focused on the things that relate to our spiritual context, but it is worth noting that Silesian migration did contribute to the Deutsch population, particularly among those who identify as Schwenkfelder.

The Schwenkfelder faith (Christian) arose in Silesia but experienced persecution, forcing the migration. Some Urglaawer have Schwenkfelder ancestry, and the Schwenkfelders today play a very active role in historical preservation and the sharing of Deutsch lore and tradition. It is also worth noting that Polish and Czech folklore tell of Rübezah! in that same region, so this is a good time to focus on common human experiences, and, as stanza 6 of the German song, "Hohe Tannen", reads:

6. Höre, Rübezah!, laß dir sagen,
Volk und Heimat sind nimmermehr frei.
Schwing die Keule wie in alten Tagen,
Schlage Hader und Zwietracht entzwei.

6. Listen, Rübezah!, let me tell you
People and homeland are nevermore free.
Swing the club like in the old days,
Beat the strife and discord in half.

The region is much more free today than it has been in the past. Perhaps the Mountain Lord has swung his club and found a way to make peace among the people of Silesia. In that spirit, we also take Polish and Czech lore into consideration. Rübezah! is known to the Czechs as *Krkonoš*, and he is said to have given sourdough bread to humankind. He is also credited as the source of a traditional sour soup called *ky-selo*. Love mushrooms? Check out the recipe: <https://en.wikibooks.org/wiki/Cookbook:Kyselo>

There are tales in which Riewezaahl is a helpful trickster and a shapeshifter (the theme of transforming turnips into people or vice-versa comes up occasionally in Germanic lore). Folks may be interested in checking

out this article: <http://www.heathenhof.com/rubezahl>

Further readings into German Silesian lore reveal a very complex Giant who is capable of meting out his own forms of justice. In the book, *Silesian Folk Tales (The Book of Rübezah!)*, by James Lee, M.D., and James T. Carey, A.M., we see the following:

- He is a Mountain Giant with trickster and shape-shifter characteristics.

- His stories frequently involve people in motion, people moving, people in need of change, etc., and he captures the spirit of the Ziegdaag "moving day" in many ways.

- He appears as many different types of beings, including men, women, etc.

- He aids people who try to improve themselves or to help others.

- He is not to be messed around with, or one will find oneself being beaten to death and hanging from a tree or being rooted firmly into the ground in the middle of a busy marketplace.

- His stories feature a lot of common tasks, including herb collecting, spinning, etc.

- Blue cornflower, already connected to long life and other magical concepts in Deutsch lore, turns up in at least one of his myths.

- Dreams and dream states turn up in quite a few of these stories, which reminds me more than a bit of the Urglaawe Schlumm, who is either a Giant or a deity who has an association with sleep.

- In the story of Mother Ilse, he plays a prank on an abusive husband that changes the domestic situation in the house (although I think the husband deserved more punishment than he got).

In the context of the Ziegdaag observance, we focus on this trickster figure's ability to bring about change through appearing as one of the common folk but performing uncommon tasks. We may also want to consider that he can be capricious; he starts off disliking some people he encounters but he may also give that person a chance. If you irritate him, it is at your own risk.

**The Troth would like to acknowledge the following Lifetime members.
We thank them for their contributions, past and present!**

Steve Abell, Rory Bowman, James Chisholm, Victoria Clare,
Gus Gissing, Kveldulf Gundarsson, Richard A. Hillstead, Susan Jerome, Patty Lafayllve,
Diana L. Paxson, Chris and Val Miller (family), Lorrie Wood
and Michael Stalnaker (family), and Ben and Mandy Waggoner (family).

How He Got His Name

He is also lovelorn. He knows the aching pain of unrequited love all too well. His nickname, Rübezahl, originates in a story about how he took the form of a peasant named Rips and proved himself a fine worker. He worked as a farmer, but the landlord was a spendthrift. He worked as a shepherd, but his master was a miser. Then he worked as a constable under a corrupt judge. He enjoyed enforcing the law properly but refused to be a part of injustice, so he was thrown into jail himself. As a shapeshifter, he was able to escape prison by jumping through the keyhole. He returned to the summit of Riesengebirge (Giants' Mountain) and wondered why nature was so kind to creatures like humans.

In a nearby kingdom, the king had a daughter named Emma. Rips set eyes upon her and fell in love, so he appeared as a prince from the East and asked the king for the princess' hand. Unfortunately, the princess was already engaged to another prince. Here's where Rips acts poorly: He created a castle and transported Princess Emma to it, where he held her prisoner until she agreed to marry him.

She became lonely, so he gave her a magic wand. With that wand, she would be able to turn turnips into anything she wanted. She used the wand to turn turnips into people, animals, and many other things. She took some comfort in this, but she had it in her mind to escape.

Rips kept a large field of turnips so that she always had a supply. One day, Emma agreed to marry Rips, so she asked him to count the number of plants that had sprouted so she would know how many people would come to their wedding. She said she needed an accurate number because even a small mistake would cause her to change her mind. Rips counted the number of sprouts twice, but the counts did not match. So he counted again, and the number was still off. While Rips was busy trying to figure out the number of turnips in the field, Emma used the wand to turn one into a horse, and she rode away. Since that time, Rips has yearned for her.

Thus, he earned his nickname because he was counting turnips while his unrequited love slipped away, using his own gift as a tool for her escape.

There are multiple lessons in this simple tale. Many of us have experienced unrequited love or have been the objects of love or infatuation that we did not share. Particularly in one's youth, one may try to find ways to hold onto love that are inappropriate and damaging to both parties. Sometimes, though, even after one learns (hopefully) some lessons and finally accepts that the relationship was not meant to be, the sting of unrequited



(Image of Rübezahl from Märchenbrunnen im Volkspark Friedrichshain in Berlin, Wikimedia Commons)

love remains. Such is the case with Rübezahl.

He appears to have learned the lesson and has let go of Emma, but, every time he is called by his nickname, the memory returns. He manages to overcome some of his pain and helps a human female, whom he initially disliked because of his experiences with Emma, to change the relationship with her abusive husband. Through some of these stories, Rips shows the need for change, the fear of change, and the outcome of painful change.

Very much akin to the observance of Ziegdaag.

Elwedritsch

Known by many variations in name, Elwedritsch is a trickster figure in Deutsch (and European German)

lore, most innocently as the target of snipe hunts. In journeywork, the Elbedritsch can mislead the worker or the client. In these circumstances, the being is considered to be a form of Elf (Elbe and Elwe both are names for elves). The name literally means “elf twitch.” On the Muunraad, should a thirteenth new moon occur after Oschdre (the spring equinox), it is called the Haas (Hare) or the Elbedritsch moon. There are Braucherei and Hexerei practitioners who know the Elwedritsch to be a true entity that can lead one astray during journeywork, but, on the whole, the modern Deutsch culture has a tendency to view the Elwedritsch through the lens of cute old folklore.

In this first year of observing Ziegdaag from a spiritual angle, we Urglaawer are encouraged to spend a few moments in silence meditating on what change means to each of us. We may have experienced trauma that requires a mindshift in order to remove obstacles to our progress. We may be happy as we are and not need any particular change, yet need to be aware when changes are taking place around us. The shifter characters in our lore provide lessons and insight into our past and our present circumstances. Change is not always pleasant, nor is it always for the better. Applying our minds and our spirits to our lives, including the process of change, can help to mitigate unpleasantness, and considering the consequences of our actions is crucial.

Rest assured that, over the next few years, the information we already have on thee characters within Deutsch lore will be organized and interpreted, and we will continue our research.

Ziegdaag will continue to grow.

Musing on Ziegdaag:

There’s a funny thing about the concept of change and the agents who instigate it. . . Most monotheistic religions eschew both. Instead they proclaim that there is one, singular, eternal truth and one way to exist. One road.

Everlasting obedience results in an eternity in heaven. Anything else is evil, or at the very least, “worldly” in an undesirable way.

Yet here are the polytheistic religions, including Urglaawe, where questions are part of the consciousness that the deities bestowed upon us. There are a multitude of roads, numerous destinations, and many ways to live life and to still be a good person.

Monotheism idealizes a lack of change, almost a static existence that we could liken to the frozen souls of the Verfrore who have been captured by the Reifries (Frost Giants) and taken to their home realm of Naddbledder. For folks unfamiliar with Urglaawe lore, the Verfrore have been removed from the evolutionary

process of life, death, and rebirth, thus weakening the advancement of humankind.

Polytheism, on the other hand, when released from the shackles of the dualism that dominates our society, looks at change occasionally as chaos, but also as part of the greater order sought by the deities. Life evolves. All of living existence is on an evolutionary trajectory. The gods created us, but our consciousness is still at a youthful level. Without change, we will not grow. Without growth, we will not be, at the end of this cosmic cycle, where the gods were at the beginning of it.

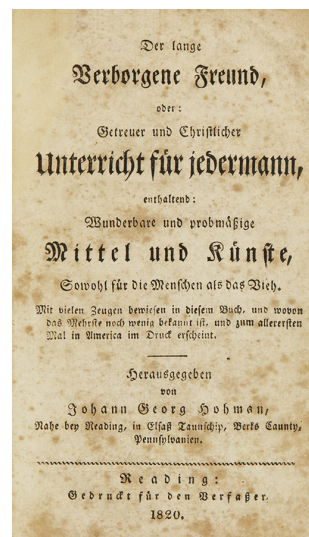
Since everything around us is also changing and evolving, the need for the expansion of our understanding of existence and how the multiverse works becomes even greater. These agents of change make us look at ourselves from many perspectives, some not so flattering.

As I ponder the lore of Rübezahl, I am reminded of some of the greater struggles with my own self during the times of transition from childhood to adolescence and, even more so, from adolescence to manhood. I know I have some regrets from those years, and I have done my best to make amends to those who were harmed by my actions, my ignorance, or my lack of action. These and other mistakes throughout my life have prepared me to try to live more deliberately.

I suspect pretty much everyone has similar feelings about periods of change and transition in their lives. . . Many may still find themselves in a prison of their own making due to fears of change or uncertainty about how to release themselves from burdens.

Pondering topics such as those is part of Ziegdaag. :)

Hail to change, and hail to adaptation.



Der Lange Verborgene Freund, “*The Long-Lost Friend*”. A compendium of spells and charms that form the basis of Pennsylvania German Braucherei or healing folk magic. Published by Johann Georg Hohman at Reading, Pennsylvania, in 1820.